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8.4 Practice Questions: Reading Comprehension

Each of the Reading Comprehension questions is based on the content of a passage. After reading the passage, answer all questions pertaining to it on the basis of what is stated or implied in the passage. For each question, select the best answer of the choices given. On the actual GMAT exam, you will see no more than four questions per passage.

Questions 467–508 — Difficulty: Easy

Line Scientists long believed that two nerve clusters in the human hypothalamus, called suprachiasmatic nuclei (SCNs), were what controlled our circadian rhythms. Those rhythms are the biological cycles (5) that recur approximately every 24 hours in synchronization with the cycle of sunlight and darkness caused by Earth's rotation. Studies have demonstrated that in some animals, the SCNs control daily fluctuations in blood pressure, body (10) temperature, activity level, and alertness, as well as the nighttime release of the sleep-promoting agent melatonin. Furthermore, cells in the human retina dedicated to transmitting information about light levels to the SCNs have recently been discovered.

(15) Four critical genes governing circadian cycles have been found to be active in every tissue, however, not just the SCNs, of flies, mice, and humans. In addition, when laboratory rats that usually ate at will were fed only once a day, peak (20) activity of a clock gene in their livers shifted by 12 hours, whereas the same clock gene in the SCNs remained synchronized with light cycles. While scientists do not dispute the role of the SCNs in controlling core functions such as the regulation of (25) body temperature and blood pressure, scientists now believe that circadian clocks in other organs and tissues may respond to external cues other than light—including temperature changes—that recur regularly every 24 hours.

Questions 467–469 refer to the passage.

467. The primary purpose of the passage is to

A. challenge recent findings that appear to contradict earlier findings

B. present two sides of an ongoing scientific debate

C. report answers to several questions that have long puzzled researchers

D. discuss evidence that has caused a long-standing belief to be revised

E. attempt to explain a commonly misunderstood biological phenomenon

468. The passage mentions each of the following as a function regulated by the SCNs in some animals EXCEPT

A. activity level

B. blood pressure

C. alertness

D. vision

E. temperature

469. The author of the passage would probably agree with which of the following statements about the SCNs?

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469. The author of the passage would probably agree with which of the following statements about the SCNs?

A. The SCNs are found in other organs and tissues of the body besides the hypothalamus.

B. The SCNs play a critical but not exclusive role in regulating circadian rhythms.

C. The SCNs control clock genes in a number of tissues and organs throughout the body.

D. The SCNs are a less significant factor in regulating blood pressure than scientists once believed.

E. The SCNs are less strongly affected by changes in light levels than they are by other external cues.

Line In their study of whether offering a guarantee of service quality will encourage customers to visit a particular restaurant, Tucci and Talaga have found that the effect of such guarantees is mixed. For (5) higher-priced restaurants, there is some evidence that offering a guarantee increases the likelihood of customer selection, probably reflecting the greater financial commitment involved in choosing an expensive restaurant. For lower-priced restaurants, (10) where one expects less assiduous service, Tucci and Talaga found that a guarantee could actually have a negative effect: a potential customer might think that a restaurant offering a guarantee is worried about its service. Moreover, since customers understand a (15) restaurant's product and know what to anticipate in terms of service, they are empowered to question its quality. This is not generally true in the case of skilled activities such as electrical work, where, consequently, a guarantee might have greater customer appeal.

(20) For restaurants generally, the main benefit of a service guarantee probably lies not so much in customer appeal as in managing and motivating staff. Staff members would know what service standards are expected of them and also know that the success (25) of the business relies on their adhering to those standards. Additionally, guarantees provide some basis for defining the skills needed for successful service in areas traditionally regarded as unskilled, such as waiting tables.

Questions 470–472 refer to the passage.

470. The primary purpose of the passage is to

A. question the results of a study that examined the effect of service-quality guarantees in the restaurant industry

B. discuss potential advantages and disadvantages of service-quality guarantees in the restaurant industry

C. examine the conventional wisdom regarding the effect of service-quality guarantees in the restaurant industry

D. argue that only certain restaurants would benefit from the implementation of service-quality guarantees

E. consider the impact that service-quality guarantees can have on the service provided by a restaurant

471. It can be inferred that the author of the passage would agree with which of the following statements about the appeal of service guarantees to customers?

A. Such guarantees are likely to be somewhat more appealing to customers of restaurants than to customers of other businesses.

B. Such guarantees are likely to be more appealing to customers who know what to anticipate in terms of service.

C. Such guarantees are likely to have less appeal in situations where customers are knowledgeable about a

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business's product or service.

D. In situations where a high level of financial commitment is involved, a service guarantee is not likely to be very appealing.

E. In situations where customers expect a high level of customer service, a service guarantee is likely to make customers think that a business is worried about its service.

472. According to the passage, Tucci and Talaga found that service guarantees, when offered by lower-priced restaurants, can have which of the following effects?

A. Customers' developing unreasonably high expectations regarding service

B. Customers' avoiding such restaurants because they fear that the service guarantee may not be fully honored

C. Customers' interpreting the service guarantee as a sign that management is not confident about the quality of its service

D. A restaurant's becoming concerned that its service will not be assiduous enough to satisfy customers

E. A restaurant's becoming concerned that customers will be more emboldened to question the quality of the service they receive

Line One proposal for preserving rain forests is to promote the adoption of new agricultural technologies, such as improved plant varieties and use of chemical herbicides, which would increase (5) productivity and slow deforestation by reducing demand for new cropland. Studies have shown that farmers in developing countries who have achieved certain levels of education, wealth, and security of land tenure are more likely to adopt such (10) technologies. But these studies have focused on villages with limited land that are tied to a market economy rather than on the relatively isolated, self-sufficient communities with ample land characteristic of rain-forest regions. A recent study of the Tawahka (15) people of the Honduran rain forest found that farmers with some formal education were more likely to adopt improved plant varieties but less likely to use chemical herbicides and that those who spoke Spanish (the language of the market economy) were (20) more likely to adopt both technologies. Nonland wealth was also associated with more adoption of both technologies, but availability of uncultivated land reduced the incentive to employ the productivity-enhancing technologies. Researchers also measured (25) land-tenure security: in Tawahka society, kinship ties are a more important indicator of this than are legal property rights, so researchers measured it by a household's duration of residence in its village. They found that longer residence correlated with more (30) adoption of improved plant varieties but less adoption of chemical herbicides.

Questions 473–474 refer to the passage.

473. The passage suggests that in the study mentioned in line 14, the method for gathering information about security of land tenure reflects which of the following pairs of assumptions about Tawahka society?

A. The security of a household's land tenure depends on the strength of that household's kinship ties, and the duration of a household's residence in its village is an indication of the strength of that household's kinship ties.

B. The ample availability of land makes security of land tenure unimportant, and the lack of a need for secure land tenure has made the concept of legal property rights unnecessary.

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land tenure has made the concept of legal property rights unnecessary.

C. The strength of a household's kinship ties is a more reliable indicator of that household's receptivity to new agricultural technologies than is its quantity of nonland wealth, and the duration of a household's residence in its village is a more reliable indicator of that household's security of land tenure than is the strength of its kinship ties.

D. Security of land tenure based on kinship ties tends to make farmers more receptive to the use of improved plant varieties, and security of land tenure based on long duration of residence in a village tends to make farmers more receptive to the use of chemical herbicides.

E. A household is more likely to be receptive to the concept of land tenure based on legal property rights if it has easy access to uncultivated land, and a household is more likely to uphold the tradition of land tenure based on kinship ties if it possesses a significant degree of nonland wealth.

474. According to the passage, the proposal mentioned in line 1 is aimed at preserving rain forests by encouraging farmers in rain-forest regions to do each of the following EXCEPT

A. adopt new agricultural technologies

B. grow improved plant varieties

C. decrease their use of chemical herbicides

D. increase their productivity

E. reduce their need to clear new land for cultivation

Line The argument for "monetizing"—or putting a monetary value on—ecosystem functions may be stated thus: Concern about the depletion of natural resources is widespread, but this concern, in the (5) absence of an economic argument for conservation, has not translated into significant conservational progress. Some critics blame this impasse on environmentalists, whom they believe fail to address the economic issues of environmental degradation. (10) Conservation can appear unprofitable when compared with the economic returns derived from converting natural assets (pristine coastlines, for example) into explicitly commercial ones (such as resort hotels). But according to David Pearce, that illusion stems (15) from the fact that "services" provided by ecological systems are not traded on the commodities market, and thus have no readily *quantifiable* value. To remedy this, says Pearce, one has to show that all ecosystems have economic value—indeed, that all (20) ecological services are economic services. Tourists visiting wildlife preserves, for example, create jobs and generate income for national economies; undisturbed forests and wetlands regulate water runoff and act as water-purifying systems, saving (25) millions of dollars worth of damage to property and to marine ecosystems. In Gretchen Daily's view, monetization, while unpopular with many environmentalists, reflects the dominant role that economic considerations play in human behavior, (30) and the expression of economic value in a common currency helps inform environmental decision-making processes.

Questions 475–478 refer to the passage.

475. Information in the passage suggests that David Pearce would most readily endorse which of the following statements concerning monetization?

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statements concerning monetization?

A. Monetization represents a strategy that is attractive to both environmentalists and their critics.

B. Monetization is an untested strategy, but it is increasingly being embraced by environmentalists.

C. Monetization should at present be restricted to ecological services and should only gradually be extended to such commercial endeavors as tourism and recreation.

D. Monetization can serve as a means of representing persuasively the value of environmental conservation.

E. Monetization should inform environmental decision-making processes only if it is accepted by environmentalist groups.

476. Which of the following most clearly represents an example of an "ecological service" as that term is used in line 20?

A. A resort hotel located in an area noted for its natural beauty

B. A water-purifying plant that supplements natural processes with nontoxic chemicals

C. A wildlife preserve that draws many international travelers

D. A nonprofit firm that specializes in restoring previously damaged ecosystems

E. A newsletter that keeps readers informed of ecological victories and setbacks

477. According to the passage, Daily sees monetization as an indication of which of the following?

A. The centrality of economic interests to people's actions

B. The reluctance of the critics of environmentalism to acknowledge the importance of conservation

C. The inability of financial interests and ecological interests to reach a common ideological ground

D. The inevitability of environmental degradation

E. The inevitability of the growth of ecological services in the future

478. Which of the following can be inferred from the passage concerning the environmentalists mentioned in line 8?

A. They are organized in opposition to the generation of income produced by the sale of ecological services.

B. They are fewer in number but better organized and better connected to the media than their opponents.

C. They have sometimes been charged with failing to use a particular strategy in their pursuit of conservational goals.

D. They have been in the forefront of publicizing the extent of worldwide environmental degradation.

E. They define environmental progress differently and more conservatively than do other organized groups of environmentalists.

Line Social learning in animals is said to occur when direct or indirect social interaction facilitates the acquisition of a novel behavior. It usually takes the form of an experienced animal (the demonstrator) (5) performing a behavior such that the naïve animal (the observer) subsequently expresses the same behavior sooner, or more completely, than it would have otherwise. One example of social learning is the acquisition of preferences for novel foods.

(10) Some experiments have suggested that among mammals, social learning facilitates the identification of beneficial food items, but that among birds, social learning helps animals avoid toxic substances. For example, one study showed that when red-wing (15) blackbirds observed others consuming a colored food or a food in a distinctly marked container and then becoming ill, they subsequently avoided food associated with that color or container. Another experiment showed house sparrows consumed less (20) red food after they observed others eating red food

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(20) red food after they observed others eating red food that was treated so as to be noxious. Studies on nonavian species have not produced similar results, leading researchers to speculate avian social learning may be fundamentally different from that of mammals.

(25) But Sherwin's recent experiments with domestic hens do not support the notion that avian social learning necessarily facilitates aversion to novel foods that are noxious or toxic. Even when demonstrator hens reacted with obvious disgust to a specific food (30) via vigorous headshaking and bill-wiping, there was no evidence that observers subsequently avoided eating that food. Sherwin's research team speculated that ecological or social constraints during the evolution of this species might have resulted in there being little (35) benefit from the social learning of unpalatability. For instance, selective pressures for this mode of learning would be reduced if the birds rarely encountered noxious or toxic food or rarely interacted after eating such food, or if the consequences of ingestion were (40) minimal. In a related experiment, the same researchers showed if observer hens watched demonstrator hens react favorably to food of a particular color, then observer hens ate more food of that color than they ate of food of other colors. These results confirmed (41) avian species can develop preferences for palatable food through social learning.

Questions 479–482 refer to the passage.

479. Which of the following best describes the main purpose of the first paragraph of the passage?

A. It explains why a particular behavior discussed in the remainder of the passage is beneficial to the animals that engage in it.

B. It introduces a concept that has been widely misunderstood among nonscientists.

C. It outlines the types of studies that have been conducted to investigate a certain animal behavior.

D. It provides information necessary to understand the nature of the phenomenon discussed in the remainder of the passage.

E. It describes a viewpoint that is called into question later in the passage.

480. According to the passage, Sherwin's research team speculated the social learning of unpalatability within a particular species might be discouraged if the animals

A. did not suffer serious effects from any noxious or toxic foods they ingested

B. consumed food in small quantities throughout the day rather than in a few large feedings

C. had an unusually large variety of foods available to them

D. interacted after feeding as well as during feeding

E. did not show signs of illness until considerable time had passed following the ingestion of noxious or toxic food

481. According to the passage, which of the following is true of the experiments on domestic hens conducted by Sherwin's research team?

A. Only a small number of observer hens appeared to learn to avoid food that was demonstrated by other hens to be noxious.

B. Observer hens ingested food preferentially only after numerous instances of witnessing demonstrator hens preferentially ingest that type of food.

C. Observer hens appeared unable to recognize when demonstrator hens found a particular food especially

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C. Observer hens appeared unable to recognize which demonstrator hens found a particular food especially palatable.

D. Demonstrator hens reacted adversely to ingesting certain novel foods.

E. Demonstrator hens altered their behavior less obviously in response to noxious foods than in response to highly palatable foods.

482. The passage indicates that which of the following is true about studies of social learning in mammals?

A. Such studies have only rarely demonstrated a capacity among mammals to learn to prefer certain foods via observation of other animals.

B. Such studies have suggested that in mammals, one function of social learning is to establish preferences for novel foods.

C. Such studies have demonstrated some capacity among mammals to learn via observation of other animals to avoid ingestion of toxic substances.

D. Such studies have been conducted primarily in the mammals' natural habitats rather than in laboratory settings.

E. Such studies have focused primarily on forms of social learning other than the acquisition of preferences for novel foods.

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